



U.S. Capitol tourists can be seen in the reflection of a panel explaining the painting “Declaration of Independence” by John Trumbull.

In the summer of 1774, as news of British actions against Boston reached Virginia, Thomas Jefferson retreated to his mountaintop villa of Monticello and began writing a secret document that could have forestalled the American Revolution — but which instead laid groundwork for it.

Jefferson had long said no one felt more strongly about maintaining ties to London than himself. The British way of government was best and “you did not even dream it should be changed,” he said, according to a friend’s account. He felt compelled to warn King George III that unless Parliament’s power was throttled, colonists would be within their rights to rebel. He begged the monarch to prevent such a catastrophe.

He stuffed two copies of the 23-page tract in his saddlebag and said farewell to his wife and their two young daughters. He headed to Virginia’s colonial capital of Williamsburg, where he planned to join a group of disaffected legislators to discuss how to respond to London’s attacks on the sister colony of Massachusetts.

Jefferson’s document read like a petition beseeching King George III to acknowledge that Parliament in London had no authority to tell its colonial subjects what to do, alleging that its actions had amounted to a “deliberate,

systematic plan of reducing us to slavery.”

Over the following two years, Jefferson’s radicalization and fame would grow, but it was this document that presaged his work on the Declaration, when he was ahead of most others in striking directly at the monarch and warning of the war that could come.

OUTWARDLY, JEFFERSON — sandy-haired, athletic and a rail-thin 6 feet 2 inches — was among the most prosperous men in British America.

Educated at the College of William & Mary in Williamsburg, he established a law practice, which brought him into contact with Virginians of all classes across the colony, from one of the wealthiest landowners to an indentured servant. He often worked on land speculation cases, venturing into an issue that would become one of the revolutionary sparks. Elected to the House of Burgesses in 1768 at 26, Jefferson soon watched a fellow legislator, Patrick Henry, attack British taxes on colonists, decrying the levy despite cries of “treason.” It was, Jefferson later wrote, the “first impulse to the ball of Revolution,” but he was not ready for it.

He began clearing land for Monticello and, in 1772, he married a 23-year-old widow, Martha Wayles Skelton, a petite woman with hazel eyes and auburn hair. The marriage enlarged Jefferson’s property, not just in land

but also in slavery; upon the death of Martha’s father, it would increase the number of Jefferson’s enslaved from 52 to 187. Jefferson envisioned that he would oversee his plantations, raise a large family and live a life of exploration, philosophical and otherwise.

“Our pillows would be soft, and health and long life would attend the happy scene,” he told a friend.

While Jefferson and many of his fellow plantation owners were increasingly outraged by British efforts to tax and restrict the colonists, Jefferson’s instincts were to push London but remain loyal. But as Parliament failed to heed his concerns, Jefferson became increasingly radicalized.

Fourteen months after his marriage, with Monticello in the earliest phase of construction, Jefferson used his seat in the House of Burgesses in Williamsburg to support a resolution that said there were “reports” that Britain was depriving colonists of “their ancient, legal and constitutional rights.” It urged action be taken to “quiet the minds of the people” and create a committee to monitor London’s actions and establish correspondence between the colonies, another layer of groundwork for uniting Americans. The measure passed unanimously, prompting Virginia’s royal governor, the Scotland-born Lord Dunmore, to alert London of this upstart 30-year-old Jefferson.

Jefferson was not yet a revolutionary, but the